

On the Divine Death

A Dialogue

Severus: Let us now contemplate the Divine Death. Consider the whole that is the union of many parts by composition. Is it not true to say the many parts are united to each other in the whole?

Interlocutor: This seems to be true, though I ask what you mean by *in the whole*?

Severus: The phrase *in the whole* is used so as to distinguish a the union of parts in a whole by composition from that of a juxtaposition. A composition is defined as the union of really distinct realities [as extremes] with a common telos [final cause] to produce an ordered unity, whereas a juxtaposition is defined as the mere concurrence of realities.

Interlocutor: Could you provide an example of these types of union?

Severus: An example of a composition would be a fiery blade out of a blade and fire, and that of a juxtaposition would be a heap of sand out of many grains of sand. A fiery blade is not merely the concurrence of a blade and fire, as with the heap of sand being the concurrence of many grains of sand, but is a new indivisible unity out of them both. Therefore, the unity of the fiery blade has extramental existence, whereas the unity of the heap only has mental existence.

Interlocutor: I see. So by 'in the whole' you mean the relation the parts in a composition have to the whole, unlike the parts in a juxtaposition.

Severus: Indeed: for me to say 'in the whole' is for me to say nothing more than 'by virtue of being unified to the whole'. Would you agree with this in full?

Interlocutor: I agree.

Severus: Recalling our analogy of body and soul, is it not right to say the soul of Severus is united to his body in his human hypostasis? And not merely a part of his body, but the whole body?

Interlocutor: Yes, this is true, and not merely to a part, but to the whole body.

Severus: So would it be true to say by virtue of the union of the soul to the whole body, it is thereby united to the parts of that body in their totality?

Interlocutor: Yes, this is true. Though I must now ask: is there a difference between the soul as part to the human and the parts of the body to the human?

Severus: Indeed, the soul relates to man as form does to the [hylomorphic] composite, while the body, and thereby its many parts, relates to man as matter does to the [hylomorphic] composite.

Interlocutor: When you call them form and matter, do you mean spiritual and physical?

Severus: I contrast form against matter not merely as spiritual against physical, but as act against potency. The soul, being the form, is the principle of activity to the potency of the body. By his soul, Severus lives and has access to the various powers of his [human] being. Furthermore, it is by the soul of Severus that Severus can truly refer to his hand as *his hand* and no one else's, whether by privation [i.e. this is not merely a hand] or opposition [i.e. this is not Eli's hand].

Interlocutor: I understand and agree.

Severus: Consider now a part of the body, the tibia. By our previous conclusion, we can say the soul is united to the tibia by virtue of being united to the whole body, correct?

Interlocutor: Yes, we can say the soul is united to the tibia by virtue of being united to the whole body.

Severus: What happens when Severus breaks his tibia into two?

Interlocutor: The tibia loses its integrity as a whole and is thereby no longer a tibia, but broken into two further parts.

Severus: There is a real [extramental] separation between the two parts, correct?

Interlocutor: Yes.

Severus: Now, is the soul itself separated from either part?

Interlocutor: This seems not to be the case, for the soul is still united to the whole body, and by extension, every part of that body: even if a part of the body is separated from another part while still being in the whole [human hypostasis]. To deny this would lead to absurdity; for instance, one hand is separate from the other hand, even though it is in the whole human hypostasis. If I affirmed that the soul was separated from either part of the tibia, I must also affirm that the soul is separated from either hand, which is absurd. Therefore, the soul is still united to both parts of the tibia even after the pieces are separated from each other.

Severus: But, considering your example of the two hands, is it not right to say if a hand is severed from the body, that [severed] hand is separated from the soul? Why does the same not apply in such a case?

Interlocutor: Hence why I was careful to add the last condition, namely that *the soul is still united to the whole body, and by extension, every part of that body: even if a part of the body is separated from another part while still being in the whole [human hypostasis]*. In the case of the severed hand, the hand is not merely separated from another part in the whole, but from the whole itself. This is not the case for the tibia, for both parts are still in the whole.

Severus: What would be the criterion by which the part is said to be in the whole?

Interlocutor: As you pointed out earlier, 'in the whole' is nothing more than 'by virtue of being unified to the whole'. Therefore, recalling the distinction between the form and matter of a hylomorphic

composite, a material part is said to be unified to the [hylomorphic] whole if it is organized by the form of that whole towards its final cause.

Severus: The organization of the material part by the form towards its final cause would be demonstrated by its natural function would it not?

Interlocutor: This is true, as function is the actualization of the potency of a material part. For example, in the case of the tibia, its final cause is to support the body by bearing weight, and its natural function would it be performing the same.

Severus: If you say the natural function of the tibia is supporting the body by bearing weight, and the tibia is therefore organized by the soul [form] and hence unified to the man [whole], would not it being broken result in an impairment of natural function, and therefore suspend its organization by the soul and be severed from the whole much like a severed hand?

Interlocutor: These two cases seem disanalogous and can be explained by accidents. Accidents exist in the substance and interfere with the organization of matter by the form. For example, the eyes of a blind man do not see; yet, it is not that they cannot see as a wall cannot see, for the formal cause of a wall does not include the power of sight, whereas the formal cause of man does. Rather, the eyes of a blind man are capable of sight but are inhibited by an accident, whether it be a cataract, a misconfigured nerve, or another impairment. Therefore, the eyes of a blind man are indeed organized by his soul toward the final cause of sight, but are inhibited by an accident from fulfilling this function. This is not the case with a severed hand, for it is not merely inhibited from exercising its natural function by an accident, but cannot function due to necrosis or lack of animation.

Severus: Therefore, a material part remains part of the whole as long as it is organized by the form of the whole toward its final cause, even if accidents prevent it from functioning properly. It ceases to be organized by the form of the whole only when it can no longer function on its own without the interference of an accident. In the case of humans, a body part would no longer be organized by the soul after it necrotizes or is animated by another form, such as in the case of cancer.

Interlocutor: Indeed.

Severus: Consider now the case of Severus undergoing a cardiac reimplantation by a surgeon. During a time in this operation, Severus's heart will be removed from his body, operated on, and transplanted back in. I ask two questions: does his heart cease to be animated immediately when separated from his body? If not, does it have an autonomous principle of animation apart from his [Severus's] rational soul?

Interlocutor: Severus's heart does not cease to be animated immediately upon separation from his body: it is capable of beating on its own even when separated from the body and thereby actually exercises its natural function of circulation. Furthermore, it cannot be an autonomous principle of animation, for that would imply Severus has a rational soul, and his heart has another soul, even if one denies rationality to that soul. Therefore, Severus's heart continues to be animated immediately after separation from the body, and the principle of its animation must be the soul of Severus himself. This would imply that mere separation from the body is insufficient to sever the part from the soul.

Severus: Indeed, this is true. I now ask, even in the splitting of the parts of the tibia from each other, is the human hypostasis of Severus split into many hypostases of each part?

Interlocutor: No, this is evidently absurd, because the parts of the tibia are still in the whole human hypostasis, therefore grounding the union of Severus's soul to both of them; whereas the severed hand, after a sufficient period of time, is no longer in the human hypostasis, therefore grounding the separation of the soul from it, and is its own hypostasis, under which it is no longer Severus's hand, but a hand.

Severus: So too do we analogize the Divine Death, the soul or form of Severus to the Divinity of the Incarnate Logos, the tibia to the Humanity of the Divine Logos, and the whole human hypostasis of Severus to the One incarnate Hypostasis of the Logos. We justify this by noting that the Divinity, which is Pure Act, is fit to be the principle of activity to the mixed act of rational flesh, which in relation to Pure Act is infinitely closer to potency than act. Therefore, the Pure Act is to Humanity as act is to potency, analogous to how form is to matter. Furthermore, if the Humanity is to be analogous to matter, then the Body and Soul are analogous to material parts. I shall now ask: was the Divinity of the Incarnate Logos separated from either His Holy Body or His Holy Soul at His death, when His Holy Body was severed from His Holy Soul?

Interlocutor: No, for just as the soul of Severus was not separated from either part of his tibia, even when each part of his tibia was severed from the other, because the parts were still in the whole human hypostasis of Severus, so too do we say the Divinity of the Incarnate Logos was not separated from either part of His Humanity, i.e. His Body and His Soul, even when His Body was truly severed from His Soul, because the parts [Body and Soul] were still in the whole incarnate Hypostasis of the Logos.

Severus: Furthermore, is the One incarnate Hypostasis split into many hypostases at His Death?

Interlocutor: No, as we have considered in the case of Severus, the separation of the parts of his tibia do not result in many hypostases because the parts of his tibia are still in the whole human hypostasis, as evidenced by the union of the soul of Severus to both. So too can we say Christ is One incarnate Hypostasis even at His death, for the separation of the parts of His Humanity do not result in many hypostases because the parts of His Humanity [His Body and Soul] are still in His One incarnate Hypostasis, as evidenced by the union of His Divinity to both His Body and Soul even when the Body and Soul have been separated from each other.

Dialogue composed by @Welde Demas